

LORENZO DA PONTE IN THE WEST

PIER MARIA PASINETTI

University of California, Los Angeles

The trouble with situations of this kind is that you are asked months ahead for a title and if, when you give it, you happen to be in a frivolous mood, you may experience some discomfort when the moment comes to justify it. Let me try to remedy the situation by describing my subject in a slightly more relaxed way as «Da Ponte: His European-American Life Pattern Observed through the Optic (*ottica*, a fashionable word) of the American West». The West which is now potentially the world's cultural center according to some authorities (not only the Governor of California but, say, Mr. Huntington who, when asked for the reason why he had decided to transfer his art and book collections to San Marino, California, prophesied — as far back as 1932, I believe — that Los Angeles was going to become the most important city in the U.S. and eventually in the world).

Without the slightest pretense at originality let us open with *the* obvious remark: Da Ponte has been an archetype of the European intellectual immigrant to the U.S.; and it would seem that for those of us Europeans who have had careers of one sort or another in this country, it should be natural to feel affinity — to «relate» — with this particular one among the various images — or shall we call them impersonations — which have formed the highly theatrical life of our man: the dissolute priest, the poet, the teacher, the librettist of course, the prisoner for debts, the bookseller, the publisher, the distiller, the impresario...

And in fact, clearly we wouldn't have been sitting here for three days to talk about him if it hadn't been for his having crossed the stormy seas from England to Philadelphia in the long and very uncomfortable days between April 7 and June 4, 1805. He was then a vigorous 56 and he would die, as we all know, in New York in his 90th year.

So his long and extremely varied biography is made to order for us to indulge in one of my favorite games, the search for what I call the incongruous contemporaneity or events occurring in far-flung places, and for the no less fascinating incongruity of certain situations and

encounters in one particular place at one particular time. A prize example of the latter is offered by Da Ponte's funeral: one of the pallbearers was, predictably enough, Clement Moore, Da Ponte's important patron, and another was Piero Maroncelli, the protagonist of the most famous leg amputated in our literary history, the one who, in Pellico's *Le mie prigioni*, after having his leg off in the Spielberg fortress by a surgeon who was also the barber of that imperial and royal institution, offered him a rose, and the surgeon — to quote the phrase that was instilled into our Italian minds since kindergarten — Took the rose, and wept, «prese la rosa e pianse».

An additional interesting point, from our — so to speak — historically global point of view, is that Maroncelli had come to America from Paris as a musician, happily married to a singer, and not as a forcefully exiled patriot, as were Borsieri and Confalonieri in 1835, along with Felice Foresti who represented here in New York Mazzini's Roman Republic and would eventually be Da Ponte's successor at Columbia.

Now we move to a major example of what I have called the incongruous contemporaneity of far-flung events. Da Ponte lands at Philadelphia of June 4, 1805, paying duty for his violin strings, his books, and other hopefully salable objects. My playful mind at this point is drawn toward images of certain events, strictly contemporaneous, occurring in these same United States, and yet, as it were, in a different planet from that of Da Ponte's landing at Philadelphia.

As is well known, the period between May 1804 and November 1806 is that of the possibly most memorable expedition in United States history, the one led by Meriwether Lewis and William Clark during Jefferson's second presidential term. That extraordinarily adventurous and well-organized group reached the Pacific from St. Louis in about eighteen months. In the Journals of the expedition, the entry by Captain Lewis for June 4, 1803, begins: «This morning early, Capt. Clark departed, and at the same time I passed the right hand fork opposite to our camp below a small island...» The situation was this: the two captains had decided temporarily to part, after «having formed a camp on the point formed by the junction of two large rivers. An interesting question was now to be determined: Which of these rivers was the Missouri...» Interesting question indeed, since — to put it telegraphically — choosing the wrong stream and missing the Missouri would have meant missing the approach to the Columbia river, which would «not only lose us the whole of this season but would probably so dishearten the party that it might defer the expedition altogether».

Of course they found the right way to the far West, which included crossing the Rocky Mountains, etc., and they reached the Pacific at the mouth of the Columbia River; you can still see a perfect reconstruction of their winter quarters at Fort Clatsop in Oregon.

Now of c
lived in this
seventh, from
beginning of t
been aware o
of the major
Nor does it n
derive from t
matter, his av
referred to as
early days, an
We go back t
years as teach
On that occa
d'eloquenza
men, through
happiness ma
put, whether
where the so
dealt with in
summer 1776
4th of July.

Along th
however, the
thrown out
territory of
self-aggrandiz
outstanding
dominating a
wrote a sonnet
near as he e
remember, I
belongs to ex
with fiery re

Attentive
autobiograph
continent be
way in which
citizen Da Po
enjoy the co
who had o
«Misfortune,

time. A prize
 one of the
 Da Ponte's
 protagonist of
 one who, in
 the Spielberg
 imperial and
 to quote the
 idergarten —
 to speak —
 had come to
 nger, and not
 nieri in 1835,
 ork Mazzini's
 successor at

ve called the
 onte lands at
 n strings, his
 mind at this
 nts, strictly
 and yet, as it
 s landing at

id November
 on in United
 Villiam Clark
 «traordinarily
 ific from St.
 pedition, the
 orning early,
 ght hand fork
 ion was this:
 aving formed
 ge rivers. An
 f these rivers
 — to put it
 the Missouri
 river, which
 d probably so
 altogether».
 rich included
 Pacific at the
 onstruction

Now of course there is no urgent reason why Da Ponte — who lived in this country through five presidents, from the third to the seventh, from Thomas Jefferson to Andrew Jackson and on to the beginning of the tenure of the eight, Martin Van Buren — should have been aware of the great historical movements and migrations, indeed of the major theme of United States history, the *Drang nach Westen*. Nor does it make much sense for us to put ourselves in his place and derive from that fantasy a feeling of missed opportunities. For that matter, his awareness of history and of what is nowadays more or less referred to as ideologies could hardly have been deep from his very early days, and here I will indulge one last time in my game with dates. We go back to the year 1776 when Da Ponte was finishing the school years as teacher of *belle lettere* and rhetoric at the Treviso seminary. On that occasion a poetry competition was announced, a *certame d'eloquenza in versi* for which he suggested the theme: «Whether men, through the laws and distributions of civil society, find the path to happiness made plainer or restricted by such laws, etc.», or, simply put, whether they are better off in a «state of nature», a proposition where the so-called basic issues or *istanze di base* of the period are dealt with in a perfunctory academic way. That was the beginning of summer 1776 and nothing prevents us from imagining that it was the 4th of July.

Along this line of academic and bookish *impegno* (let us observe, however, that for proposing that theme our man was apparently thrown out of the Treviso seminary and forbidden to teach in the territory of the Venetian Republic) we have Da Ponte's brief and self-aggrandized flirtation with the politics of Giorgio Pisani, the most outstanding among the impoverished noblemen who opposed the dominating aristocratic élite. In praise and defense of Pisani, Da Ponte wrote a sonnet, interminably *caudato*; in one of the *code* he came as near as he ever did to a political slogan, or material for a TV spot; remember, he says, that this is a communal republic, and that it belongs to everyone and to no one, which sounds even less charged with fiery revolutionary spirit in the original Venetian language:

Metéve nel pensiero
 che questa xe repubblica comun
 et che la xe de tuti o de nissun.

Attentive renders of Da Ponte's staging of himself in his autobiography may recall that during his trip through the European continent between 1798 and 1799 he met Pisani again; and this is the way in which many years later *citoyen* Pisani is evoked by American citizen Da Ponte: «Going through Ferrara I stopped for a few days to enjoy the company of my former protector and friend Giorgio Pisani, who had obtained his freedom». But he is soon disappointed. «Misfortune, the many years in prison, the fall of the republic and the

misadventures of his family had changed him so much that he no longer looked like the wise, knowing citizen of the republic but a furious, desperate revolutionary...»

In the same passage, and in a quite opposite key, he mentions his encounter with the poet Ugo Foscolo in Bologna. But this portrait of Foscolo is hardly that of an *impegnato* citizen. Even Foscolo's political oratory is praised in literary terms for its «lively, noble, and luminous images», and there is praise for his «divine» poetry to which Da Ponte immediately adds — in a spirit that we would now call promotional — that he, Da Ponte, alone was responsible for having made Foscolo known and admired by «the most awakened spirits of this illustrious and, «(mi sia permesso di dirlo a mio vanto) da me solo italianizzata città.»

Again we find ourselves in the area of the obvious: as a Venetian citizen, Da Ponte was no *impegnato* European seeking freedom through revolution of some sort; as an American citizen, he was no seeker of fortune in the vast and vastly unexplored new land. With all this, we keep admiring his energy, endurance, and good humor maintained in all sorts of natural and personal difficulties — for indeed, at the time, even for a man like him whose American dreams were geographically limited, more or less, to the New York-Philadelphia axis, life was full of hazards. It was, so to speak, far western enough, what with pigs eating garbage in front of New York hotels, dreadful sanitation, an epidemic of yellow fever. And what about the countryside? One needn't go to Missouri or to Oregon territory, of course, to experience «primitive nature». But precisely here, from whatever evidence we have of Da Ponte's vision and reactions, we see that he, for better or worse, incurably was the European man of letters.

Let me first take a couple of typical passages from the Lewis and Clark Journals. On June 3, 1805, Captain Lewis writes: «...Between the time of my a.m. and meridian, Captain Clark and myself strolled up to the top of the heights in the fork of these rivers, from which we had an extensive and enchanting view. The country, in every direction around us, was one vast plain in which innumerable herds of buffalo were seen, attended by their shepherds, the wolves. The solitary antelope, which now had their young, were distributed over its face, some herds of elk were also seen. The verdure perfectly clothed the ground. The weather was pleasant and fair».

And this is a sample from Captain Clark: «I...struck the little river, at 20 miles, passing through a level plain. At the little river we killed two buck elk and dined on their marrowbones, proceeded on a few miles and camped, having killed 2 deer which were very fat. Some few drops of rain today; the evening fair, wind hard from the N.E. I saw great number of elk, antelope, mule deer, and wolves, and one bear on this little river».

And now t
near Sunbury:
marmorei e gr
profondissime,
aspetto... e tra
altra sorte di se
sonaglio, che s
nulladimeno ur
quella maestos

Who is the
man of feeling,
the whole, is a

Of course.
theater. Hence
appoint him «p
to associate
accumulation o
lessons. What
cultural wave I
might be intere
had been that o
the theaters an
— on a pretty
encounter — a
years old, the
Columbia Colle
correctly inform

Details of I
subject. All I l
conclusion, the
potential, Da
cheek, address
well-known fil

Well, let us sir
the early introc
of Italian opera
himself — tha
tanto...quanto
planted, in the
The range and
described. Let

h that he no
epublic but a

entions his
his portrait of
colo's political
and luminous
hich Da Ponte
romotional —
made Foscolo
this illustrious
o *italianizzata*

as a Venetian
king freedom
n, he was no
land. With all
good humor
— for indeed,
dreams were
k-Philadelphia
estern enough,
otels, dreadful
at about the
n territory, of
ly here, from
ctions, we see
opean man of

the Lewis and
s: «...Between
myself strolled
rom which we
every direction
erds of buffalo
.. The solitary
l over its face,
tly clothed the

the little river,
river we killed
eded on a few
fat. Some few
the N.E. I saw
nd one bear on

And now this is, in front of nature, our Da Ponte in Pennsylvania near Sunbury: «...Ruscelli, cascate d'acqua, collinette, dirupi, massi marmorei e gruppi multiformi si stendono in due valli vastissime e profondissime, che metton capo con altre montagne di non dissimile aspetto... e tra un'infinità di cervi, cignali, di pernici, di fagiani e d'ogni altra sorte di selvaggina, de' lupi, delle volpi, degli orsi e de' serpenti a sonaglio, che sebben raramente assaliscono il passeggero, aggiungono nulladimeno un certo orror dilettevole, una certa paura di solennità a quella maestosa solitudine...»

Who is the narrator here? Not the pioneering explorer, he is the man of feeling, capable of «orror dilettevole», and the landscape, on the whole, is a composition, not a scene but, rather, scenery.

Of course. The man is a professional man of letters and man of the theater. Hence his American problem. No emperor here, who may appoint him «poet of the imperial theaters», no impresario with whom to associate himself in show business and in the dangerous accumulation of debts. No ready buyers of Italian books and Italian lessons. What he needed then was coming across someone on his cultural wave length, a member of that predictably small elite which might be interested in his not at all popular culture ware. His terrain had been that of the eighteenth-century adventurers and voyagers, of the theaters and courts *ancien régime*, all of this — let us never forget — on a pretty solid basis of conventional classical studies. The crucial encounter — as we all know — was with Clement Moore, then 28 years old, the son of the president of the former King's College, then Columbia College, about a hundred blocks south of here, if I am correctly informed.

Details of Ponte's career as cultural promoter are of course not my subject. All I have time for is trying to define, by way of tentative conclusion, the design, the general pattern of that career. Above all, its potential, Da Ponte's activities seen as archetypal. With tongue in cheek, addressing his old venetian friend Michele Colombo in a well-known *filastrocca* he asks:

Da' confini ove il sol nasce
Fin là dove il mar si cerca
Chi mai fe', sin dalle fasce
Quel ch'io fatto ho in Novajorca?

Well, let us simply answer that he made himself the major symbol of the early introduction of Italian literary language and literary texts, and of Italian opera, into «Novajorca» where he had found — as he put it himself — that «quanto alla lingua e letteratura italiana se ne sapeva tanto...quanto della turca e della cinese». And that the seeds he planted, in the two areas, caught, with different degrees of success. The range and limits of his success have been amply documented and described. Let us confine ourselves to a couple of final quotations

which illustrate his wit and sagacity in observing the «cultural scene». In the *filastrocca* to Colombo mentioned above he seems to anticipate, with naive humor, the perennial academic dichotomy between the so-called humanists and the supposedly always richer and more self-assured scientists:

In America i collegi
Son con senno regolati,
I maestri son egregi
E son ben remunerati,
Con lodevol preferenza
Si coltiva ogni scienza,
Soprattutto la numerica,
In cui celebre è l'America.

Let us hasten to add, with inevitable realism, that even though — to put it in the quickest terms — Italian institutions and university departments have considerably proliferated and developed, with the most heterogeneous results, yet the more «seminal» of Da Ponte's activities was in the opera. No image in his life is perhaps more poignant than that of 77 year old Da Ponte watching in a New York theater a performance, which he had been instrumental in organizing, that he referred to as «il mio Don Giovanni», nearly forty years after its opening in Prague. Italian opera, needless to say, became part of the very tissue of American «vita di società» in ways that poetry and letters can only dream of. Think of the golden years at the turn of the century and try, playing with alliterative names, to compare the resonance of the tenor Caruso with that of the poet Carducci, the first Italian novel prose.

Now a corollary on «vita di società». In the pages on Sunbury, Pennsylvania, from which I have already quoted, Da Ponte describes also «quella parte della borgata che sulla sponda dilatasi della Susquehanna», and informs us that «da quella amenissima parte di Sunbury era la casa presa a pigione da me, nel centro delle più rispettabili famiglie del luogo...» Da Ponte and society. It disappointed him, of course, in his major aspiration.

Alla man che vi die' que' tesori
Voi negaste la cetra e la tromba;
Alla fronte strappate gli allori,
Del cui nome la scena rimbomba.

In one of the footnotes to the *filastrocca* for Colombo he writes: «Sperai scriver un dramma per l'America come ne scrissi 36 per l'Europa. Non n'ebbi l'ordine».

Arthur Livingston, in his introduction to one of the English translations of the *Memorie* says that «the Da Pontes were the discovery of the New York social season of 1807» and in fact it is easy

to imagine the
genuine article
Europe. Living
revelation...»
conclude, fan
can be seen
directions «fr
use of the wo
has the flair
from dress
fashionable,
conclude tha
from Canada
the way to E

ultural scene». s to anticipate, between the er and more

ven though — und university ped, with the of Da Ponte's perhaps more a New York trumental in , nearly forty dless to say, ietà» in ways olden years at ve names, to of the poet

on Sunbury, nte describes dilatasi della ima parte di ro delle più society. It

o he writes: rissi 36 per

the English es were the fact it is easy

to imagine that in cultural circles he must have represented the genuine article, a living, available fragment of cultured, artistic od Europe. Livingston also writes that «Mrs. Da Ponte's cuisine was a revelation...» And here, without entering into further details, we may conclude, fantasizing perhaps, that the American career of our man can be seen as prefiguring a pattern which has developed in all directions «from coast to coast» up to our days, based on an extensive use of the word «culture» — the pattern, that is, of the European who has the flair to introduce, at the right moment, from art to cuisine, from dress to machinery, that which is destined to become fashionable, trendy, «in». So let us stretch things somewhat and conclude that the spirit of Da Ponte may be found to have extended from Canada in the Venetian Republic, via Vienna, London, etc., all the way to Beverly Hills.